



■ By Damayanti Datta

Sushila Sahay greets the morning cheerfully. Up at the break of dawn, she pins her hair in a braid and potters around the garden of her Sunder Nagar home in Delhi. She then wakes the five-year-old up, readies her for school, supervises the kitchen, chooses the menu and ticks off the gardener for not setting the urns straight. A breakfast of fruit and she goes out — she likes to shop for her groceries. Nothing extraordinary about this — it's the sort of lifestyle many of us lead. But Sahay is different. In October she will turn 100.

How does science explain someone like her? How can a woman about to start her second century be so full of life, while others decades younger fade away? A long life has always been shrugged off as a gift (or a curse) from the gods. "Who wants to live till 100? Not me," Aditi Jha, a 20-something corporate